Starlink in India: disrupting connectivity or daring gamble?

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It was April 2025. Parnil Urdhwareshe (Telecom, 2021), market access director for Starlink India, faced a critical strategic decision regarding the company's commercial approach for entering the Indian satellite broadband market. The decision carried significant implications not only for Starlink's commercial success but also for its broader ambition of extending digital connectivity to India's underserved regions.

India had close to 1 billion internet users with an attractive market-growth rate of 36% per year (Dubey, 2025), yet substantial gaps in connectivity remained between urban and rural regions. At the same time, the country's telecommunications sector was highly competitive and was dominated by established operators such as Reliance Jio and Bharti Airtel providing affordable broadband and mobile internet services. Starlink's price was 10–14 times higher than that of local internet providers (Moneycontrol, 2025). Starlink's premium pricing (INR [1] 25,000–35,000 or US$280–390) for equipment and INR 5,000–7,000 monthly fees [2] contrasted sharply with India's low broadband average revenue per user (INR 400–600)[2]. Although India represented one of the world's largest digital opportunities, the market was characterized by intense competition, complex regulations and significant affordability challenges.

By the first half of 2025, Starlink, the satellite internet venture developed by SpaceX, was preparing to expand its presence in India (Kumar and Kumar, 2025). This renewed effort followed an earlier attempt to enter the Indian market in 2021, when the company was required to suspend pre-bookings for not having the necessary regulatory approvals (Behura, 2025). Competitive pressure had become immediate. Airtel had partnered with Eutelsat-OneWeb, while Reliance Jio had collaborated with Société Européenne des Satellites (SES) (Mathur, 2025). Other foreign satellite internet providers, such as Amazon's Project Kuiper and Inmarsat, were also seeking approvals to operate in India (Kashyap, 2023). Together, these developments illustrate the alliance-based structure of India's emerging satellite broadband market, as summarized in Table 1.

While Starlink's partnerships with Airtel and Jio helped address regulatory and market-access challenges, they also created new strategic considerations related to market positioning, pricing and the company's long-term competitive advantage. As Starlink prepared for commercial entry, Urdhwareshe faced a critical question: What business strategy should Starlink adopt to achieve sustainable growth in the Indian market while balancing affordability, profitability and its broader objective of expanding digital connectivity?

About Starlink

Space Exploration Technologies Corporation, commonly known as SpaceX, was an American aerospace company founded by Elon Musk in 2002 (Britannica money, 2025),



Disclaimer. This case has been taught in an upper-division undergraduate decision-making course; minor details have been adapted for classroom use and clarity.

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Table 1 Key foreign–domestic alliances and regulatory milestones in India's satellite broadband market (2019–2025)

Year	*Key event*
2019	■ Amazon announced Project Kuiper, a satellite broadband initiative
2021 Nov – 2021	■ Starlink began accepting pre-orders for satellite broadband services in India ■ Indian authorities stated that Starlink lacked the required license to operate commercially and directed the company to suspend pre-bookings
2022	■ Bharti Airtel and OneWeb strengthened their partnership to provide satellite broadband services in India, with Airtel becoming OneWeb's exclusive distribution partner ■ Reliance Jio and SES established orbit connect India, a joint venture to provide satellite-based broadband services using GEO and MEO satellite constellations ■ Inmarsat entered a strategic partnership with BSNL to expand satellite connectivity services across India
2023–2024	■ OneWeb (partnered with Airtel) received regulatory approvals from IN-SPACe to commence commercial satellite broadband services in India
Early 2025	■ Amazon's Project Kuiper formally sought entry into satellite broadband market ■ Starlink continued pursuing the regulatory approvals required to commence commercial satellite broadband operations in India
March 2025	■ Airtel announced a partnership with Starlink to distribute Starlink's satellite broadband services in India ■ Reliance Jio announced a partnership with Starlink to expand satellite broadband connectivity through Jio's retail and digital infrastructure

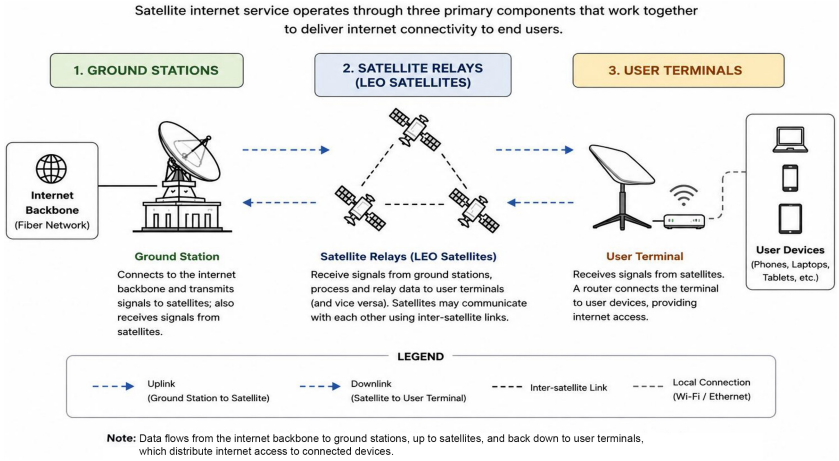
Note(s): Indian telecom firms such as Airtel, Jio and BSNL participate in the satellite broadband market primarily through partnerships or joint ventures with international satellite operators. The table therefore focused on the alliances, entry initiatives and regulatory milestones most relevant to Starlink's strategic decision
Source(s): Authors' own work by compiling from cited case sources

with the objective of reducing the cost of space transportation and enabling broader access to space. One of SpaceX's major initiatives was Starlink, a satellite-based internet service designed to provide high-speed internet connectivity through a constellation of low earth orbit (LEO) satellites (SpaceX, 2026). In January 2015, Elon Musk announced plans to set up Starlink in Redmond, Washington (Rohit and Rohit, 2025). Starlink used a constellation of LEO satellites to provide high-speed internet services (Yasar, 2024). Instead of using cable technology, such as fiber optics, to carry internet data, a satellite system used radio signals through the vacuum of space. Figure 1 illustrated how the user terminal, satellite constellation, ground station and internet backbone interact to deliver satellite broadband connectivity. Geostationary earth orbit (GEO), medium earth orbit (MEO) and LEO were the three distinct types of satellite orbits, characterized by their altitude above Earth's surface. Table 2 compared LEO, MEO and GEO satellites in terms of altitude, orbital period, principal uses, advantages and limitations.

Starlink used a large constellation of smaller satellites in LEO which had substantially lower latency [3] (approximately 25–50 ms [4]) than traditional satellite systems (typically around 600 ms) (Business Today Desk, 2025). As of March 28, 2025, 7,105 of 7,135 Starlink satellites in orbit were operational (Pultarova *et al.*, 2025; Jonathan's Space Report | Space Statistics, 2026). Starlink's unprecedented mega-constellation was transforming activity in LEO. The company planned to expand its constellation from 12,000 to 42,000 satellites by 2034–2035, which was five times the total number of objects humans had ever placed into orbit prior to this project (EJIL: Talk!, 2025).

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Figure 1 Satellite internet architecture



Source(s): Authors' own work, adapted from Shapournia (2026)

Table 2 Types of satellite and their characteristics

Types of satellite	*Altitude*	*Orbital period*	*Uses*	*Advantages*	*Disadvantage*
Low earth orbit (LEO)	160–2,000 km above Earth's surface	Relatively short, often less than 90 min for a single orbit	Earth observation (remote sensing, climate monitoring), communication (satellite internet) and space station operations	Lower latency, higher bandwidth and lower cost to launch and maintain	Satellites move rapidly across the sky, requiring more satellites for continuous coverage
Medium earth orbit (MEO)	2,000–35,786 km above earth's surface	Longer than LEO but shorter than GEO, ranging from 2–24 h	Navigation (GPS, Galileo), communication and some telecom networks	Balance between LEO's low latency and GEO's wide coverage	Satellites move across the sky, requiring more satellites for continuous coverage than GEO satellites do
Geostationary earth orbit (GEO)	Precisely 35,786 km above earth's equator	Same as Earth's rotation (24 h), making satellites appear stationary relative to the ground	Telecommunications (TV broadcasts, satellite internet), weather monitoring and data transmission	Fixed position provides constant coverage over a large area, requiring fewer satellites	Higher latency compared to LEO and MEO due to the greater distance

Source(s): Pandian and Pandian (2023), Wilson (2024) and TE Connectivity (2026c)

Starlink was the only satellite internet provider to offer speeds up to 220 Mbps and low latency (Anders, 2025). During peak usage hours, Starlink's median latency in the USA decreased by approximately 30%, from 48.5 ms to 33 ms and Starlink also reported latency reductions of up to 25% in the USA and 35% in places outside the USA (Starlink, 2026).

Starlink's offering

Across several countries, Starlink's base plans offered download speeds ranging from 50 Mbps [5] to 150 Mbps. Upload speeds usually fell between 10 and 20 Mbps. The "Priority

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plans" offered speeds of up to 220 Mbps (Gupta, 2024a). Table 3 compared Starlink's US consumer plans by monthly price, speed, equipment cost and data allowance. High-speed internet is very useful for activities such as streaming, online gaming and video conferencing.

Starlink offered multiple service plans targeting residential, business and "on-the-go" users. "Residential plans," priced between US$80 [6] and US$120 per month, offered speeds of approximately 50–250 Mbps. Priority plans targeted business users, while Roam plans served mobile customers. Equipment generally cost around US$349, although prices varied by location and equipment type. In some locations, Starlink also imposed a US$100 congestion charge. For small enterprises, "Local Priority plans" began at US$65 per month for 50 GB of priority data and could serve as backup connectivity. "Roam plans" began at US$50 per month, while the US$165 Roam Unlimited plan did not impose a data cap. "Global Priority plans" began at US$250 per month for 50 GB [7] of priority data and targeted maritime and international mobility applications.

There was no official confirmation of Starlink's service price in India. According to some industry experts, the first year's expenses for Starlink's corporate plan could be close to INR 215,600 (approximately US$2,450). From the second year onward (see Table 4 for Starlink's anticipated offering in comparison with Airtel and Jio's existing enterprise offering), the annual cost would decline to INR 163,316 (approximately US$1,860) including applicable taxes (Gupta, 2024b), because the user equipment represented a one-time first-year expense. In addition to the monthly service charge of INR 10,469 (US$120), the base price for user equipment was anticipated to be around INR 52,242 (US$599). Reliance Jio's Business plans cost, on average, INR 12,000 to INR 15,000 annually, although certain Jio plans (e.g. the 7,001 Plan and the 10,001 Plan) could cost as high as INR 120,000 (US$1,364) per year [8]. Similarly, Airtel's high-speed (500 Mbps to 1 Gbps) corporate plan could be available for INR 100,000–141,000 per year (Airtel Office internet, 2026).

Table 3 Starlink's subscription plan for consumer market (in USA)

Starlink plan	*Monthly price*	*Speed range*	*Equipment costs*	*Data allotment*
Residential lite	US$80	50–100Mbps download, 5–20Mbps uploads	US$349 upfront	Standard unlimited
Residential	US$120	150–250Mbps download, 5–20Mbps uploads	US$349 upfront	Standard unlimited
Local priority	US$65–US$540	40–220Mbps downloads, 8–25Mbps uploads	US$349–US$1,499 upfront	50 GB–2 TB, standard unlimited thereafter
Roam	US$50 to US$ 165	5–50Mbps downloads, 5–25Mbps uploads	US$349 or (US$599 for the Starlink Mini)	Standard unlimited

Source(s): Anders (2025)

Table 4 Comparison of Starlink, Airtel and Jio enterprise internet tariffs in India

Factors	*Starlink (anticipated single speed tier enterprise plan)*	*Airtel (Enterprise plan)*		*Jio (Enterprise plan)*	
		Standard speed tier	*High speed tier*	*Standard speed tier*	*High speed tier*
Speed	50–200 Mbps	100–200 Mbps	500 Mbps to 1 Gbps	100–200 Mbps	1 Gbps
Initial upfront fee	INR 52,242 (US$599)	INR 1,000	Nil	INR 1,000	Nil
Monthly fee	INR 10,469 (US$120)	INR 799	INR 6,999–9,999	INR 799	INR 7,000–10,000
Tax and other charges	30%	18%	18%	18%	18%
Approximate first-year cost	INR 2,15,600 (US$2,450)	INR 12,314–141,600 (US$140–1,610)		INR 12,314–141,600 (US$140–1,610)	

Source(s): Moneycontrol (2025)

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Telecommunication industry

The telecommunications services market was defined as the total volume and value of both the fixed-line and wireless telecommunications markets. The market volume was defined as the number of fixed-line and wireless subscriptions (MarketLine, 2024). The fixed-line telecommunications market was defined as the revenues obtained by operators from voice telephony and fixed internet lines (wirelines), rather than wireless systems. This market consisted of voice telephony segments, circuit-switched and voice over internet protocol (packet-switched voice subscriptions) and narrowband (transmission speed < 128 Kbps [9]) and broadband (transmission speed > 128 Kbps) internet segments. The wireless telecommunications services market included cellular (mobile) phones, pagers and other wireless services.

Attractiveness of the Indian market

Several factors contributed to the attractiveness of the Indian telecommunications market. These included a large and growing internet user base, increasing digital adoption, substantial unmet broadband demand in rural regions and strong government support for digital infrastructure development. During the period of financial year (FY) [10] 2020 to FY 2024, the Indian telecom industry's gross revenue grew at a compound annual growth rate (CAGR) of 7.35%, reaching INR 3.36tn in 2024. However, the growth rate of wireline subscribers between 2015 and 2023 remained modest. During that period, although the number of urban wireline subscribers grew from 20.99 million to 29.12 million, the number of rural wireline subscribers dipped from 4.53 million to 2.72 million (Statista, 2026). The number of cellular subscriptions grew at a CAGR of 28.56% during 2000–2023. However, this growth had stagnated since 2016, and since then, the number of subscriptions hovered between 1 billion and 1.2 billion (Statista, 2026).

As of 2023, India had approximately 900 million wireless internet subscribers, and in 2024, the number of internet users reached approximately 950 million, representing 159 million households (Statista, 2024a) and was expected to reach a number over 1.2 billion in 2029 (Statista, 2024b). 950 million internet users were equivalent to the 70% of internet penetration in 2025 (Statista, 2025a), covering 42% of the rural population. India's share of mobile traffic in total Web traffic was 79% in the first half of 2024.

In 2024, approximately 700 million users surfed the internet through mobile devices. Also, during the year 2024, per 100 inhabitants in India, approximately 66 persons had access to mobile broadband connections (Statista, 2024c). Between 2018 and 2023, the number of fixed broadband subscriptions in India increased significantly, rising from 18.17 million to 39.48 million (ITU, 2025). In the same timeframe, the number of wireless broadband subscribers in India increased by 1.6 times, reaching 866 million (Statista, 2024d). In terms of smartphone subscriptions by technology, 22% used 5G services and 76% used 4G services (Statista, 2026). As per the survey, monthly data usage by Indian consumers in 2022 and 2023 was estimated as 14.4 exabytes [11] and 17.4 exabytes (Nokia, 2024a), which came down to the fact that the average monthly data consumption by an Indian was 19.5 GB per month and 24.1 GB per month in 2022 and 2023, respectively (Nokia, 2024b).

Competition dynamics

The Indian telecommunications market was highly concentrated, with four major operators— Reliance Jio (Jio), Bharti Airtel Ltd. (Airtel), Vodafone Idea Ltd. (VI) and Bharat Sanchar Nigam Limited (BSNL) (Statista, 2024e). Among these firms, Jio and Airtel dominated both subscriber growth and revenue generation, creating a highly competitive environment for new entrants.

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Airtel achieved the highest revenue in 2024, totaling INR 1,499m (Bharti Airtel, 2024), while Jio followed with a revenue of INR 1,329m (RIL, 2024). VI, with a revenue of INR 426m (Yahoo! Finance, 2025) and BSNL, significantly trailing at INR 213m, were notably outpaced by their competitors [Department of Telecommunications (India), 2024]. The four players controlled almost 98% [12] of the Indian market (TRAI, 2024). Other small players were OneOTT Entertainment, Hathway Cable & Datacom, Kerala Vision Broadband and others. According to McKinsey's business-to-business (B2B) Telecom Insights, B2B [13] revenue across global telcos generally accounts for 15%–25% of total operator revenues (Playing to win in B2B Telecom, 2026). Airtel Business (B2B) accounts for roughly 14%–16% of Airtel's overall India revenue (Airtel, 2026a).

India's internet speeds were on an upward trajectory, yet they continued to fall short of those in numerous high-income nations. Despite notable advancements in mobile internet speeds, especially with the rollout of 5G, India's position in global rankings for both mobile and fixed broadband speeds remained average. Ookla [14] reports that since 5G was introduced, India's speed performance increased by a factor of 3.59 (Classes and Classes, 2025). In September 2022, the median download speed was 13.87 Mbps; it increased to 50.21 Mbps in August 2023. The median download speed in India stood at approximately 100.78 Mbps, while the upload speed was recorded at 9.08 Mbps, accompanied by a latency of 30 ms (Desk, 2024). According to the latest Ookla Speedtest Global Index[15] 2023 report, India jumped 72 places, from 119th place to 47th position in the Speedtest Global Index. In terms of mobile internet speeds, India ranked 25th worldwide as of November 2024, as per the Speedtest Global Index (Classes and Classes, 2025). In terms of mobile internet, VI offered the quickest 4G download speed, while Airtel and Jio came in second and third, respectively. People using BSNL's 4G service said that it was the slowest (Khatri, 2024a). However, Airtel outperformed its competitors in the broadband internet service category. The average download speed for Airtel fixed broadband customers was 44.1 Mbps, and with Jio's fixed broadband, customers could expect an average download speed of 33.8 Mbps (Khatri, 2024b).

India ranked third (Fleck, 2023) in terms of lowest mobile internet cost (at US$0.17 per GB) in the world (see Figure 2 for India's mobile-data price compared with selected international markets). Depending on factors such as speed, data allowance and bundled services, the monthly cost of broadband internet in India ranged from around INR 399–3,999 (Gadgets 360, 2026). Indian broadband providers offer competitive alternatives to Starlink. Jio Fiber (from INR 399/month) and Airtel Xstream (INR 499–3,999/month) provide speeds up to 2 Gbps with bundled over-the-top (OTT) and Direct-to-Home (DTH) services. BSNL and Tata Play Fiber offer speeds up to 1 Gbps and include unlimited calls or TV bundles. Budget options include Hathway (INR 425/month for 40 Mbps; requires prepayment) and Excitel (30–200 Mbps), as well as reliable high-speed plans from ACT Fibernet. For businesses, Airtel and Jio offer 100–200 Mbps plans for INR 12,000–15,000 annually. Table 5 summarized selected entry-level broadband plans and highlighted the low-cost terrestrial alternatives available to Indian consumers.

Considering the current offering in the Indian market, consumers did not seem to have any complaints regarding the speed or quality of the internet. As revealed by a survey conducted in India from January 24 to December 24, among around 1,600 participants aged 18–54 years, 54% were very satisfied and 39% were satisfied with the current internet speed provided by companies (Statista, 2025b).

Satellite internet operators in India

Until 2017, when it hit US$128.7bn, income in the global satellite service business increased steadily, but after a drop in 2018, the trend resumed until 2023 (Satellite Industry Association, 2024a). Approximately 89% of this revenue originated from the consumer segment, while 11% was derived from the enterprise segment (Satellite Industry

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Figure 2 Average cost of mobile data in selected countries (US$/GB)



Source(s): Fleck (2023)

Association, 2024b). As of 2024, Starlink had the highest number of satellites in orbit. There were several other operators, such as OneWeb with 648 satellites, Intelsat with 90 (N2YO.com, 2024), SES with 70 (About us, 2016) and Amazon with 27 (Staff, 2025). With this trend, it was expected that by 2033, four mega constellations [earth orbit (LEO) were Telesat, Amazon (Project Kuiper), SpaceX (Starlink) and OneWeb (IEEE Conference Publication | IEEE Xplore, 2021)] would capture 65% of the market share of the satellite service industry (Novaspace, 2024).

A recent analysis by KPMG in India estimated that the country's satellite communication market, valued at US$2.3bn in 2025, was expected to grow to US$20bn by 2028 (Barik, 2024). Morgan Stanley reported that India had 290.4 million households lacking broadband access, presenting a significant market opportunity for satellite operators (Barik, 2024). While Starlink enters with a massive LEO mega-constellation, it faced heavily entrenched domestic players like Bharti Airtel and Reliance Jio, state-owned BSNL, who already decided to leverage horizontal partnerships with various foreign partners like OneWeb and SES. Strategic advantages and disadvantages of those SatCom players were summarized in Table 6.

During 2021–22, Airtel and OneWeb were teaming up to bring satellite-based internet access to India (Bharti, 2026). Both OneWeb and Airtel were aiming to deploy their satellite services commercially and Airtel was the only distributor for OneWeb in India. In addition to OneWeb, Airtel also signed a deal with Musk's SpaceX (ET Bureau, 2025), which came as a surprise, given that Airtel already had a tie-up with Eutelsat OneWeb, a rival to Starlink. The

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Table 5 Subscription plan of broadband internet services in India

Broadband plan	*Features*	*Operator*	*Speed*	*Data*	*Base plan*
BSNL fiber rural home Wi-Fi/ GHAR KA Wi-Fi for INR 399	Speed 4 Mbps beyond 1,400 GB	BSNL	Up to 30 Mbps until 1,400 GB	Unlimited data download	INR 399 for 1 month
JioFiber INR 399 Monthly Plan	Benefits 1. Unlimited data @ 30 Mbps 2. Unlimited voice, Validity – 30 days, Notes: Commercial usage policy applicable to all unlimited plans, GST additional on applicable components	Jio	30 Mbps	Unlimited	INR 399 for 1 month
Airtel Broadband Plan for INR 499	Talktime: unlimited, includes Airtel Thanks benefit, router free on 6 months/12 months plan	Airtel	40 Mbps	Not reported in the cited source	INR 499 for 1 month
ACT A – Max 500 50 Mbps Speed for INR 500	Equal upload and download speed, zero-touch installation	ACT	50 Mbps	Not reported in the cited source	INR 500
Excitel for 3 Months of INR 592/ month	Add On: OTT Standard – INR 100*(GST exclusive starting price), OTT Premium – INR 200 (18% of GST excluded starting price), Amazon Prime – Available free with this Pack	Excitel	NA	Not reported in the cited source	INR 592 for 3 months
Tata Play 50 Mbps speed for INR 649	Free installation and dual band router included	Tata Play	50 Mbps	Not reported in the cited source	INR 649 for 1 month
Hathway Family Plan: INR 525 for 1 Month	Benefits: 5 GHz dual band router free to use* | Pay for 11 months and get 12th month free, installation: zero installation charges on 6 and 12 months, no security deposit	Hathway	100 Mbps	Not reported in the cited source	INR 525 for 1 month
YOU Broadband Unlimited Plan for INR 2,400		YOU Broadband	20 Mbps	3.5 TB/Month	INR 2,400 for 360 days
Tikona 40 Mbps speed for INR 599 per month	FUP limit per month: unlimited, installation charges: INR 1,000, subscription Amount: INR 1,887, Available in select buildings only, number of simultaneous logins allowed from a single location: 1, No of device registrations allowed: 5	Tikona Broadband	40 Mbps	Not reported in the cited source	INR 599 for 1 month

Note(s): Currency conversion rate: US$1 = INR 88

Source(s): Broadband Plans | High Speed Internet Plans & Offers – NDTV Gadgets 360. https://www.gadgets360.com/broadband-plans. Jio (2026), Airtel (2026b), BSNL (2026), TATA PLAY FIBER (2026), Desk (2025c), Best Internet service provider in India. (2026), Excitel (2025), Moneycontrol (2025)

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Table 6 Advantages and disadvantages of Satcom competitors in India

Operator/venture	*Core specialization and user/market base*	*Strategic advantages*	*Strategic disadvantages/challenges*
Airtel and OneWeb	Market position: one of the top two telecom giants in India Target base: nationwide retail and enterprise consumers	Holds exclusive distribution rights for OneWeb in India Already secured commercial broadband approval from IN-SPACe, providing an early-mover advantage	Navigating a complicated, competitive relationship with partner Starlink over spectrum allocation
Starlink (SpaceX)	Core Tech: LEO mega-constellation (over 7,100 operational satellites) Target base: Premium consumers, remote/underserved areas and businesses	Formed horizontal distribution pacts with major local rivals Jio and Airtel Can leverage Jio's massive retail stores and Airtel's enterprise sales suite	Delayed commercial launch as it still awaits regulatory permissions from IN-SPACe High-cost technology creates intense friction with India's price-sensitive consumer base
Jio and SES (orbit connect India)	Market position: leading Indian telecom operator Core tech: combined GEO/MEO satellite constellations	Strong financial and infrastructural backing (Jio holds a 51% equity stake) Already secured regulatory permissions from IN-SPACe to operate	GEO/MEO constellations naturally suffer from higher latency compared to pure LEO networks Needs to supplement its ground-based infrastructure in remote regions
Amazon (Project Kuiper)	Core tech: Planned LEO mega-constellation Core specialization: low-latency, high-speed internet tailored strictly for underprivileged and unconnected areas	Backed by Amazon's massive global scale, infrastructure and financial resources Recognized as one of the major upcoming global mega-constellations	Significantly lagging in deployment, with only 27 satellites in orbit compared to Starlink's thousands Still in the early phase of awaiting mandatory DoT and IN-SPACe regulatory nods
Inmarsat and BSNL	Market position: BSNL is state-owned but severely trails private players financially (INR 213m revenue) Core specialization: Enterprise mobility – specifically aviation, maritime, defense and government disaster management	BSNL provides a robust, deeply rooted local presence and extensive operational capabilities Already secured regulatory clearances to deliver mobile broadband to high-value sectors BSNL understands ultra-low-cost rural delivery (e.g. its INR 399 "Ghar Ka Wi-Fi" broadband plans)	BSNL severely lags private networks financially and had a consumer reputation for the slowest 4G mobile speeds. Service is specialized for institutional/niche sectors rather than mass-market consumer scaling

Source(s): Authors' own work by compiling from cited case sources

contentious topic of satcom spectrum pricing and allocation also pitted Airtel and Starlink against one another (ET Bureau, 2025). However, Airtel stated – "By adding Starlink, (in addition to its existing alliance with Eutelsat OneWeb) to its offerings, Airtel would further its ability to offer nationwide connectivity and connect previously underserved areas, particularly those with limited to no coverage today," Airtel further added – "With Starlink enterprise suite, Airtel would be able to offer enterprises, businesses and communities comprehensive and seamless connectivity packages." While Starlink was still waiting for permissions, OneWeb already received authorization from IN-SPACe to commence commercial broadband services in India, potentially providing an earlier commercialization advantage than Starlink (ET Bureau, 2023).

Under Orbit Connect India, another major Indian telecom giant, Jio and SES joined in the year of 2022 to provide satellite internet services in India (SES, 2025; Reuters and Business Standard, 2024).'Jio Platforms and SES would own 51% and 49% equity stakes in the joint venture (Livemint, 2022). The joint venture would use a combination of geostationary earth orbit (GEO) and MEO satellite constellations to provide high-capacity broadband services (Mukul, 2022). The Indian space regulator, IN-SPACe, granted Orbit Connect India the required permissions to operate satellites in India (Business Today, 2024). Jio also had a contract with Starlink that was not about replacing SES in their current JV, rather, it was about using Starlink's technology and network to maybe improve Jio's broadband offers, particularly in places with inadequate or nonexistent ground-based infrastructure (Desk, 2025a). Moreover, Jio would be able to provide Starlink solutions through its retail stores and online platforms, expanding access to satellite broadband nationwide (Business Today, 2025).

Another international player, Inmarsat entered in strategic partnership with a state-owned telecom company BSNL in 2022 to gain access to the Indian market and deliver its services. Inmarsat provided the satellite infrastructure and expertise, while BSNL provided the local presence and operational capabilities (Majithia, 2021). Furthermore, BSNL "secured necessary regulatory clearance to deliver the satellite provider's mobile broadband services to customers across government, aviation and maritime sectors", thereby allowing Inmarsat to provide its services. Inmarsat's services were already used by the Indian government and the defense sector for connectivity and for disaster management during emergencies (Inmarsat Corporate Website, 2018).

Project Kuiper, an internet initiative launched by Amazon using satellite, first announced in 2019 to deploy more than 3,000 satellites into LEO and finally joined the competition officially in the beginning of 2025 (Desk, 2025b). The aim of Project Kuiper was to provide low-latency, high-speed internet to India, with a particular focus on underprivileged areas (Moneycontrol, 2024; Bloomberg, 2021).

Regulatory authority

The primary regulator of the Indian telecommunications sector was the Telecom Regulatory Authority of India (TRAI), whilst the Department of Telecommunications (DoT) functioned as the governmental ministry overseeing communications (Government of India, 2026). TRAI developed proposals regarding spectrum allotment and pricing for the licensing system as well as the length of the licensing period for satellite internet services. TRAI's recommendations were often implemented, despite the DoT possessing the authority to issue binding directives to TRAI (Bhirani and Bhirani, 2021). TRAI was recognized as the ultimate authority in regulating the Indian telecoms sector because TRAI allegedly rejected many petitions by the DoT that requested certain adjustments to the recommendations on the authorization regime (Florentyna, 2025).

Like other nations, TRAI was trying to figure out how to allocate spectrum for satellite internet administratively. So, instead of holding auctions, the government would distribute satellite-

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based spectrum for internet services, in line with TRAI's recommendations (Online, 2024). Administrative allocation of spectrum was the method where the government directly assigned spectrum licenses to specific entities based on certain eligible criteria, without a bidding process or auction (Allocation of satellite spectrum, 2026), whereas in the auction process, the government sold spectrum licenses to the highest bidder (Kumar, 2024). Administrative allocation did not mean that the company would get the spectrum for free. A nominal fee would be charged to cover all administrative costs incurred by the government (Kumar, 2024). A portion of the gross revenue generated by all satcom players in India would be taxed at 3% as a spectrum usage charge, even though the Indian government did away with the spectrum tax for terrestrial network providers such as Reliance Jio, Airtel and Vodafone (Tnn, 2025). This was in addition to the 8% license fee that all telecom companies were required to pay (Tnn, 2025). Reactions to the administrative approach to spectrum allocation among telecom players were mixed. Telecom leaders such as Jio and Airtel advocated for auctions to promote equitable competition and optimization of government revenue, whereas Starlink preferred administrative allocation to minimize expenses (Singh, 2025).

TRAI also suggested capping the duration of satellite licenses at five years for satcom players to understand the initial adoption (Reuters, 2025). The shorter period might help the government understand the sector's growth and take informed action on future spectrum allocation. Reliance expressed its interest for three years, subsequently urging Indian government to reassess the market (Reuters and Business Standard, 2025). In contrast, Starlink urged Indian government to designate spectrum for 20 years (Gupta, 2024c), emphasizing the importance of "affordable pricing and long-term business strategies." Another Indian telecommunications provider, Bharti Airtel, similarly endorsed a license term spanning three to five years (Gupta, 2024d). Other than TRAI, with IN-SPACe was assigned as a single window agency for authorization (IN-SPACe, 2026), along with the Indian Space Research Organization (ISRO, 2026) helped to control space activity, including satellite internet.

Starlink's India entry strategy

Mr Elon Musk's ventures, spanning from electric vehicles (Tesla) to space exploration (SpaceX) and even high-speed transit (The Boring Company), already earned the reputation of running ambitious projects in different industries. A key defining feature of Musk's business ventures was steadfast commitment to vertical integration and proprietary technology (Wu *et al.*, 2022). By maintaining control over critical stages of the value chain, SpaceX was able to coordinate satellite manufacturing, launch operations and network deployment within a single organizational ecosystem. This approach offered greater operational control, reduced dependence on external suppliers and enabled the company to capture a larger share of value creation. At the same time, a highly integrated model required substantial investment and limited reliance on external partners.

However, the Indian market presented a different set of strategic challenges. As discussed earlier, regulatory approval processes, spectrum allocation requirements and the dominance of established telecom operators created significant barriers for foreign satellite service providers. Starlink's approach was also influenced by its earlier experience in India. In 2021, the company began accepting pre-orders for its satellite broadband service before obtaining the required regulatory approvals. Subsequently, Indian authorities stated that Starlink did not possess the necessary license to operate commercially and directed the company to suspend pre-bookings (Onanuga, 2021). Consequently, Starlink adopted a market-entry approach that differed from SpaceX's traditional operating model. Rather than relying exclusively on internal capabilities, the company announced partnerships with Bharti Airtel and Reliance Jio to leverage their distribution networks, market reach and regulatory expertise.

The partnerships offered several advantages, including faster market access and reduced regulatory uncertainty. However, they also introduced strategic complexities. Both Airtel and Jio were simultaneously developing satellite communication capabilities through

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partnerships with OneWeb and SES, respectively. As a result, Starlink's collaborators could also emerge as important competitors in the evolving satellite broadband market.

The success of Starlink's India strategy would therefore depend on its ability to balance the benefits of collaboration with the need to maintain a sustainable competitive position. While partnerships could help Starlink overcome regulatory and market-entry barriers, the long-term attractiveness of the opportunity ultimately depended on the economic fundamentals of the satellite communications industry. Understanding these industry-wide cost structures and economic viability challenges was therefore critical to assessing the prospects of satellite broadband services in India.

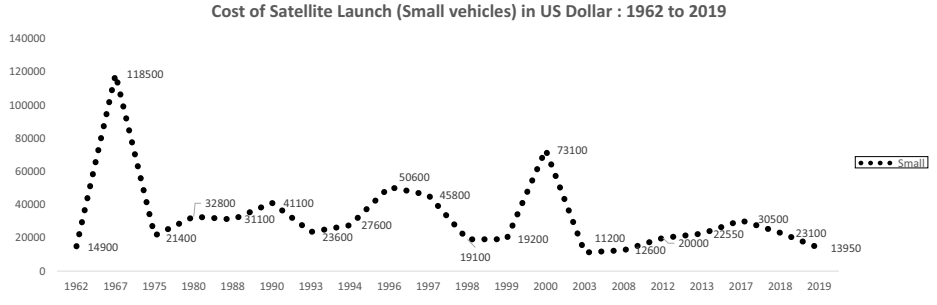
Economic feasibility

SatCom players incurred several costs, including ground infrastructure, satellite manufacturing, launch costs and ongoing operations. These costs might significantly impact the overall cost of satellite internet services, especially for companies attempting to offer competitive prices. LEO satellites were situated at lower altitudes, so coverage was limited. For example, if a single satellite provided 960 gigabits per second of bandwidth and transmitted data at around 100 megabits per second, it would take approximately 460,000 satellites to reach half of the global population (Goldman Sachs, 2025).

Minimizing manufacturing expenses constituted the most formidable challenge; the expense of larger communications satellites typically ranged from US$50,000 to US$60,000 per kilogram and companies needed to reduce costs by 90%–95% via several strategies, including automation, economies of scale and reduced component expenses, to ensure the financial viability of large LEO constellations (McKinsey and Company, 2020). Typical LEO satellites had a mass ranging from 100 to 1,000 kg (220–2,200 pounds). Their average cost varied from US$0.5–40m, and from design to completion, the satellite took approximately 18 months (TE Connectivity, 2026a). Ground stations and gateway antennas were fundamental terrestrial equipment, and their installation had always been relatively expensive. The price of antennas featuring electronically scanned apertures needed to decrease to reach the consumer market, which had the greatest revenue potential and was essential to justify these constellations.

However, the good news was that the cost of launching satellites had been decreasing. Figure 3 traced the historical decline in the cost of launching payloads to LEO, a trend that could improve the long-term economics of satellite broadband. According to the research, the average yearly rate of decline in launch costs for satellites in LEO was 5.5%, while the rate of drop for altitude-adjusted average launch prices per kilogram was 4.4% (Adilov *et al.*, 2024). If current trends continued, the average cost to launch a satellite into LEO

Figure 3 Historical cost of launching payloads to low earth orbit (US$/KG)



Source(s): Our World in Data (2022)

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would be less than US$1,000 per kilogram between 2045 and 2076 and less than US$100 per kilogram by the next century (Adilov *et al.*, 2024). While launch costs decreased due to reusable launch vehicles and private-sector competition, they remained a substantial expense. Some satellites used commercial off-the-shelf components, which were readily available and cost-effective, while others required relatively expensive specialized, space-ready components (TE Connectivity, 2026b).

Road ahead

Although Starlink possessed significant technological advantages, success in India was far from guaranteed. The company faced a complex strategic challenge involving market positioning, pricing, partnerships, regulatory requirements and competition from both domestic telecom operators and emerging satellite internet service providers. As Starlink prepared for the next phase of its India strategy, Urdhwareshe needed to determine how the company could translate its technological capabilities into a sustainable and scalable business model. What strategic approach should Starlink adopt to establish a viable long-term position in the Indian market while remaining consistent with its broader mission of expanding digital connectivity?

Notes

[1.] INR, Indian rupee.

[2.] An exchange rate of US$1 = INR 88 is used throughout the case.

[3.] The term "latency" refers to the time it takes for a packet to travel from your Starlink router to the internet and back. This time was typically expressed in milliseconds. A different name for this was "round-trip time" (RTT).

[4.] 1 ms or millisecond = 0.001 s.

[5.] Megabits per second was abbreviated as Mbps.

[6.] Symbol of currency of the USA (US$).

[7.] Binary system: 1 GB = 1,024 MB = 1,073,741,824 bytes; decimal system: 1 GB = 1,000 MB = 1,000,000,000 bytes.

[8.] https://enterprise.jio.com/Enterprise/myjio-ent/SMB/plans/?typeirfiber

[9.] Kbps stands for kilobits per second.

[10.] FY represented the financial year. In India, the financial year starts on April 1 and ends on March 31 of the next year.

[11.] 1 exabyte (EB) = 1,000,000,000 gigabytes (GB) (in decimal system) or 1 exabyte (EB) = 1,073,741,824 gigabytes (GB) (in binary system).

[12.] Distribution of internet subscribers in India as of December 2023: Jio (50.23%), Airtel (30.24%), VI (14.68%) and BSNL (3%).

[13.] B2B stands for business-to-business. It describes a business model where commercial transactions, services or data exchanges happen directly between two companies, rather than between a company and an individual consumer.

[14.] Ookla was best known for its Speedtest® app, which was a widely used tool for measuring internet speeds and network performance.

[15.] Please see https://www.speedtest.net/global-index for a detailed report.

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Abstract

Title – *Starlink in India: disrupting connectivity or daring gamble?*

Research methodology – *This case was developed from secondary sources only. The secondary sources included industry reports (Statista.com, McKinsey report), company annual reports, news reports, social media sites and company websites. More than 100 sources, including technical documents, have been consulted. This case has been classroom tested with Master of Business Administration (MBA) students and final-year undergraduate students in a strategic management course.*

Case overview/synopsis – *Starlink, SpaceX's satellite internet initiative, is expanding into India's massive digital market of over 950 million users. While poised to bridge the rural–urban digital divide, the company faces severe challenges, particularly from a premium price architecture that is 10–14 times more expensive than entrenched local alternatives. To navigate strict domestic telecom regulations and accelerate market entry, Starlink strategically pivoted from an independent model to horizontal partnerships with telecom giants Reliance Jio and Bharti Airtel. However, these same partners are actively developing their own rival satellite networks, threatening to lessen their reliance on SpaceX over time. Ultimately, Starlink's expansion hinges on a critical strategic dilemma: balancing high cost of offering against a highly price-sensitive market, forcing the company to either significantly reduce expenses or target a specific niche willing to pay a premium for low-latency connectivity.*

Complexity academic level – *The case study, "Starlink's Expansion into the Indian Market," offers a rich and relevant learning experience for advanced undergraduate, MBA and executive MBA students. This case serves as a dynamic illustration of complex strategic decisions, particularly in the context of marketing, technology management, international business and strategy formulation.*

Keywords *International business strategy, International market entry, International marketing, Marketing, Marketing strategy, Regional marketing, Strategic management, Strategy*

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